

Wheel Alignment Shop — Things You Need to Know

Practical checklist for starting in New Brunswick · companion to the Business Plan and Financial Model · October 2026

Bottom line: check the numbers with real local quotes, charge for NB rust, keep a winter cash cushion, and don't spend on premium equipment before you have customers.

1. Check the numbers before you trust them

- **Call 5–6 local shops as a customer.** Ask their 4-wheel alignment price and how soon they can book you. Same-day booking means the area has spare capacity; a wait of a week or more means there's room for a new shop.
- **Test a lower volume in the model.** Change the maturity assumption from 9 to 6 alignments a day. If the business only works at 9 a day, it's too risky.
- **Get real quotes** for the lease, the alignment machine and lift, and insurance, then type them into the spreadsheet.

2. Issues specific to New Brunswick

- **Rusted, seized parts:** road salt seizes tie rods and adjusting bolts, so many alignments take longer than expected or need parts. Put a **"seized/rusted parts" fee** (about \$30–60) or extra-labour quote on your price list from day one, or rusty cars will eat your profit.
- **Cash flow over winter:** December to February is slow. Keep at least 2–3 months of costs in the bank going into winter. Fall tire swap and storage money helps carry you.
- **Your opening date:** opening in March or April catches pothole season, and the fall tire rush arrives within six months. Opening in winter is the hardest start.

3. Choosing the building

Many buildings that look suitable won't work for an alignment shop. Check:

Check	What you need
Floor	Level and solid enough to bolt down a lift
Ceiling height	At least 12–14 ft for a lift
Bay doors	At least 10–12 ft wide and tall, so trucks and SUVs fit
Zoning	Confirm with the city that automotive repair is allowed before signing
Lease terms	3–5 years with a renewal option, landlord approval for the lift, free rent during setup
Storage	Dedicated space to store tires if you sell storage

4. Taxes and money

- **Incorporate** once profit is meaningful. Small-business corporate tax in NB is about 11.5% combined (federal 9% + NB 2.5%), much lower than personal rates. Have an accountant set this up.
- **HST:** charge customers 15% and remit it to the CRA. Claim back the HST you pay on equipment — a big refund on an \$85k+ setup.
- **Equipment write-offs:** equipment can usually be deducted from taxable profit over several years, lowering tax in the early years. Ask your accountant how this applies to your purchases.
- **Bookkeeping:** use QuickBooks or Wave, and keep business and personal money separate from day one.

5. Equipment tips

- **Ongoing software costs:** alignment machines need yearly vehicle-database updates (\$500–2,000/yr) plus periodic calibration. Ask suppliers before you buy.
- **Training and service:** buy from a supplier that offers training and local service — a broken aligner during the spring rush is a disaster.
- **Used equipment** can save 30–50%. Make sure the database can still be updated and the sensors calibrated.
- **Electric vehicles** are heavier, wear tires faster and need correct lift points. More business, but check your lift's weight rating (aim for 10,000–12,000 lb).

6. Licensing and staff

- **Technician certification:** ask NB Apprenticeship and Occupational Certification whether the work you plan requires a certified (Red Seal) automotive service technician.
- **Inspection-station licence:** becoming a Motor Vehicle Inspection Station requires a licensed inspection mechanic.
- **Hiring:** finding good technicians is one of the biggest problems in this trade. Line up candidates before you open, and consider being a hands-on owner at first.
- **Insurance:** garage liability (covers damage to customers' cars while you have them), property and equipment coverage, and business-interruption cover.

7. Building customer trust

- **Give printouts:** hand every customer a before-and-after alignment printout. It builds trust and justifies the price.
- **Offer free alignment checks** during tire swaps — many customers then buy the full alignment.
- **Collect reviews:** ask every happy customer for a Google review; that's how people pick a shop.
- **Guarantee your work:** e.g., a free recheck within 30 days or 1,000 km.

8. Biggest mistakes to avoid

1. Spending too much on premium equipment before you have customers.
2. Running out of cash in the first winter.
3. Not charging for seized or rusty parts.
4. Offering alignment only, without tire swaps, storage and parts.
5. Signing a lease before confirming zoning and the building's specs.

9. Consider buying an existing shop

Buying a tire or repair garage that already has customers, equipment and a lease can be faster and less risky than starting from scratch. Look on BizBuySell Canada and with local business brokers.

Next step: take the Business Plan PDF and the Financial Model spreadsheet to a **BDC advisor or Opportunities NB**. Their advice is free, they can review the numbers, and they can help you apply for financing.

Tax rates, fees and costs are estimates as of October 2026; confirm with an accountant and the relevant NB agencies.